

Fifty difficult readings

An image-review pilot

Private review addendum | 19 September 2026

The pilot confirms that useful work remains. Direct image inspection supports sixteen literal readings, verifies twelve links to clearer overlapping scans, and partly recovers two names. Two missing-letter completions remain conjectural; eighteen items remain unresolved.

These are register items, not unique words. Some refer to the same signature or duplicate leaf. The deliberate sample cannot estimate the recovery rate for the remaining 1,150 items.

Outcome	Items
Image-supported reading	16
Clearer duplicate witness	12
Partial reading	2
Conjectural completion	2
Unresolved	18

What changed

Brushy and build become readable through letter forms and same-hand comparison. The Hancock initials read Wm L. The initial immediately before Hawkins reads F; the preceding word still needs checking. Guthrie is recoverable, but the notary's given name is not.

Two proposed harmonizations fail the image check: the later slip visibly says Sat, and the deed docket says 91 while the separate recording certificate says 92. Preserve those distinctions.

Status and how to use this report

This is an AI-assisted editorial review, not an independently human-verified scholarly edition. The original v1.0 files are preserved. The companion corrected-excerpts.md applies the sixteen literal changes and two partial surname recoveries only to an explicitly labeled draft overlay. Missing and obscured text stays marked, with separate witness notes.

For full-size source crops and original/contrast comparisons, open evidence.html from the downloaded addendum folder. decisions.json and corrections.json retain the item-level decisions and reversible changes. All fifty decisions follow in this report.

Source credit: George Douglas Papers, 1830-1939, CRS MS 5, ACU Special Collections and Archives, Brown Library, Abilene Christian University. This is a private family contribution; no ACU endorsement or review is represented.

Method and practical limits

Sample and provenance

Fifty items were selected before adjudication: 29 tentative readings, nine unread spans, nine losses and three obstructions, across nineteen selected scan pages. The other agent's text-only review was read first, so this was not a blinded comparison. Agreement between the AI-assisted family and annotated editions is not independent human confirmation.

Image evidence

Four supplied source PDFs were verified by SHA-256. Native embedded images were extracted, rotated in exact 90-degree steps as needed and cropped without upscaling. Forty-three original RGB regions and their grayscale/1% autocontrast variants are provided. Six also have documented gamma adjustments. No generative restoration was used. The manifest records sources, coordinates, rotation, processing and checksums.

Overlaps were matched by handwriting, line breaks, signatures and layout. Words supplied by a clearer duplicate are identified as such. Tonal changes cannot recover physically missing paper or ink.

Local OCR diagnostic

Apple Vision completed 76 local runs: nineteen regions, two image variants, language correction on and off. Nine image-supported target readings were checked in the top-ranked output. Each configuration recovered only Sat (one of nine). No additional accepted reading came from OCR. This is a small difficult-crop diagnostic, not a character-error rate or a benchmark of trained handwriting recognition.

Transkribus and Kraken were not tested. A handwriting-specific model remains an option, after establishing checked reference text and a held-out evaluation set. The pilot does not show that every useful tool has been exhausted.

Recommended sequence

First map the remaining duplicate leaves, then prepare letter-form examples by writer. Audit entire lines around dense uncertainty clusters: on 06-063 and 06-116, some previously confident surrounding words also need checking. Obtain independent human paleographic review before treating the changes as a university reference contribution.

Methods background

[Smithsonian historical handwriting guide](#)

[Transkribus data preparation](#)

[Kraken documentation](#)

[OCR-D workflows](#)

These method references do not validate the readings. Full citations, rights information and reproduction instructions are in README.md. Nathaniel Lynn Douglas's father remains unestablished.

Decisions and evidence

Locators name the source PDF and its one-based scan page, followed by the existing transcript paragraph/item. They are not original manuscript page numbers. Evidence region names locate PNG crops in the companion images folder.

02-003-U001 | Image-supported reading

02-003-P01 | [[Of?]] → Of

The rounded opening letter and looped descending f survive at the ragged left edge. Native-resolution inspection supports Of; the sentence supplies corroboration, not the missing strokes.

Evidence: 02-003-opening.

04-002-U002 | Unresolved

04-002-P03 | [[Walkers?]] → Walkers remains tentative

The opening W and tall internal strokes fit Walkers, but degraded ink and the ruled line interfere with the ending. Neither an apostrophe nor the full place-name spelling is secure.

Evidence: 04-002-place.

04-002-U007 | Image-supported reading

04-002-P04 | [[Alfred?]] → Alfred

The name after Uncle shows A, a tall l, descending f and the final d. The separate letter on 06-097 also visibly names Uncle Alfred and reports his death and wound interval. This does not establish Nathaniel Lynn Douglas's father.

Evidence: 04-002-alfred, 06-097-alfred.

04-002-U013 | Unresolved

04-002-P05 | [[J. H. Scott?]] → J. H. Scott remains tentative

The enlarged signature suggests J H and a surname beginning Sc, but fading interrupts the ending. Preserve the uncertain full signature rather than resolving it from an expected correspondent.

Evidence: 04-002-signature.

04-017-U001 | Unresolved

04-017-P01 | [[Yellow?]] → Yellow / Willow unresolved

The initial and following short strokes are obscured by a dense blot. Both proposals remain possible; contrast does not isolate the identifying letters.

Evidence: 04-017-heading.

04-017-U003 | Image-supported reading

04-017-P02 | [[Denmark?]] → Denmark

The word after wrong in has a D-like opening, en, m and the final ark strokes. The familiar phrase agrees with, but is not substituted for, the visible writing.

Evidence: 04-017-denmark.

04-043-U001 | Clearer duplicate witness

04-043-P03 | [[obscured: fold]] → hearing of their said Husbands they the said Laura Robinson and Susanna Bell acknowledged

The fold in 04-043 hides this span. Scan 04-044 shows the same handwriting before and after it and exposes the intervening words. Retain the obstruction marker on 04-043 and supply a cited witness note; these words were not recovered from the fold itself.

Evidence: 04-043-fold, 04-044-opening.

04-043-U002 | Image-supported reading

04-043-P04 | [[S. M.?]] → Wm L

The clearer overlapping image shows the W, raised m and separate L before Hancock. Comparable signatures on 05-151 and 05-157 have the same forms. Do not expand Wm to William in the literal transcript. The adjacent precinct number is outside this item and still needs review.

Evidence: 04-043-signature, 04-044-signature, 05-151-hancock, 05-157-hancock.

04-043-U003 | Image-supported reading

04-043-P06 | [[Rusk?]] → Hood

Both scans show an H followed by two rounded o forms and a final d crossing the flourish below. Rusk does not fit those letters. The county name is not inferred solely from Glen Rose.

Evidence: 04-043-county, 04-044-county.

04-043-U006 | Clearer duplicate witness

04-043-P08 | [[lost: reproduced portion ends]] → Continuation includes March A. D. 1875

Matching handwriting and the same date line establish the overlap. The later scan exposes March A. D. 1875 below the cropped ending. Keep the loss marker and link 04-044-P06; do not invent the connector still at the torn edge.

Evidence: 04-043-ending, 04-044-ending.

04-044-U001 | Clearer duplicate witness

04-044-P01 | [[lost: reproduced portion begins mid-sentence]] → Opening is preserved in 04-043-P03

The names, clause order and repeated lower lines identify this as the same acknowledgment. The preceding image preserves At the Same time and Place Personally appeared Laura Robinson ... wife of the said J. M. Bell. Preserve the crop boundary and cite that witness instead of implying the words are visible on scan 44.

Evidence: 04-044-opening, 04-043-fold.

04-044-U003 | Image-supported reading

04-044-P02 | [[S. M.?]] → Wm L

The W with raised m, followed by L and the distinct capital H of Hancock, can be compared in three signatures. This is the same signature as 04-043-U002, so it is a second register item, not a second independent recovery.

Evidence: 04-044-signature, 05-151-hancock, 05-157-hancock.

04-079-U002 | Image-supported reading

04-079-P01 | [[Burky?]] → Brushy

The continuous forward writing shows Br-u-sh-y across the interference from reverse-side writing. The long s/h strokes and descending y support Brushy, not Burky.

Evidence: 04-079-brushy.

04-080-U001 | Image-supported reading

04-080-P01 | [[Hedlie?]] → build

The b-u-i-l-d forms in helping build agree with the same writer's later build in build a house of worship on this page. This same-hand comparison is stronger than the carpentry context alone.

Evidence: 04-080-build, 04-080-build-exemplar.

05-024-U001 | Image-supported reading

05-024-P02 | [[A?]] → F

The initial immediately before Hawkins has the upper flourish and lower return of F, matching the F in Benj. F. Hawkins on 05-026; it does not have the two bowls of B. The preceding word, currently transcribed By, may itself be a compact Benj abbreviation and needs separate whole-line review.

Evidence: 05-024-docket, 05-026-hawkins.

05-035-U001 | Image-supported reading

05-035-P01 | [[Sat?]] → Sat

The later identifying slip visibly has S-a-t, including a closed a and tall crossed t; no descending p is visible. The contextual review proposed Sep using the adjacent letter's transcript. Preserve Sat as the slip's literal wording. The companion heading/date should be assessed separately; this pilot does not normalize its month or weekday.

Evidence: 05-035-slip, 05-036-heading.

05-037-U001 | Image-supported reading

05-037-P01 | [[Chadens?]] → Chadsey's

The name is split across two manuscript lines: Chad at the end of one, sey's at the start of the next. Reading both line ends together resolves the earlier collapsed Chadens guess.

Evidence: 05-037-chadsey.

05-130-U001 | Unresolved

05-130-P03 | [[lost: torn edge]] → Loss remains

The torn edge removes the beginning of the line before My recovery. Tonal changes cannot recover paper that is absent. A connective such as on would be a conjecture, not a reading.

Evidence: 05-130-loss.

05-130-U005 | Conjectural completion

05-130-P04 | [[lost: torn edge]] → Conjectural [C]rop

The remaining rop and the cotton-bale context make crop a strong completion, but the C is physically missing. Keep the loss marker in the literal text and put [C]rop only in a clearly labeled conjectural note.

Evidence: 05-130-loss.

05-130-U008 | Conjectural completion

05-130-P04 | [[lost: torn edge]] → Conjectural [se]ttlement

The surviving ttlement and the phrase the sale and favor settlement. The beginning is absent at the torn edge; [se] is editorial supply and cannot be classed as image recovery.

Evidence: 05-130-loss.

05-142-U002 | Image-supported reading

05-142-P03 | [[Ellis?]] → Ellis

Despite fading, the opening looped E, two I ascenders and final is are visible in the county field. The second occurrence at the foot of this certificate has the same letter pattern.

Evidence: 05-142-certificate.

05-142-U004 | Unresolved

05-142-P03 | [[June 4?]] → June 4 remains tentative

Faint traces fit June 4, but the numeral and some connecting strokes are too weak for a secure literal reading here. The date on another part of the instrument is contextual support, not a replacement for this field.

Evidence: 05-142-certificate.

05-142-U010 | Unresolved

05-142-P03 | [[Waxahachie?]] → Waxahachie remains tentative

The overall word shape and several ascenders fit Waxahachie; too many central strokes remain faint after contrast and gamma adjustment. Preserve the marker rather than resolving from the usual clerk's-office formula.

Evidence: 05-142-certificate.

05-142-U012 | Image-supported reading

05-142-P03 | [[Ellis?]] → Ellis

At the foot, the E, paired I strokes and is ending are clearer than in the header and agree with it. The handwriting supports Ellis without needing the county's expected identity.

Evidence: 05-142-certificate.

05-146-U001 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-146-P01 | [[lost: cropped top]] → Survey description continues from 05-145-P03

The same lines beginning 18 varas an Elm recur on both scans. The preceding image exposes the survey text above that point, including the cedar bearing. Retain the cropped-top marker and link the earlier scan; this does not count as newly reading the same survey twice.

Evidence: 05-146-top, 05-145-survey.

05-146-U002 | Unresolved

05-146-P02 | [[H. D. Winniford?]] → H. D. Winniford remains tentative

The surname is largely visible, but the second initial is washed out and can resemble another letter. The grantor's spelled-out name elsewhere supports H. D.; it does not make the signature's exact lettering secure.

Evidence: 05-146-signatures.

05-146-U003 | Unresolved

05-146-P02 | [[McCrary?]] → McCrary remains tentative

Alice E and the beginning of the surname can be followed, but the end enters a heavy shadow. Brightening does not separate all the letters. The acknowledgment identifies Alice E McCrary, but that identity alone does not verify this signature.

Evidence: 05-146-signatures.

05-146-U004 | Unresolved

05-146-P02 | [[illegible: signatures in shadow]] → Signatures in shadow remain unread

Brightening the shadow exposes additional pen strokes but does not establish complete names or their order. Names of other grantors in the deed body must not be presented as recovered signatures.

Evidence: 05-146-signatures.

05-146-U005 | Unresolved

05-146-P03 | [[lost: cropped beginning]] → Cropped beginning remains missing

Both overlapping scans begin after the acknowledgment's opening. The clearer duplicate helps with its date, but does not supply the person's name or the missing opening clause.

Evidence: 05-146-date, 05-147-date.

05-146-U006 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-146-P03 | [[2nd?]] → 2nd, verified on 05-147-P01

The shaded date on scan 146 is consistent with 2nd; scan 147 exposes the same dated line and clearly reads 2nd. Record the witness explicitly rather than claiming all three characters are clear in the shaded scan.

Evidence: 05-146-date, 05-147-date.

05-146-U007 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-146-P03 | [[illegible]] → Jany, verified on 05-147-P01

The date line, seal and A. O. Walker signature align across the scans. The clearer copy shows the abbreviation Jany. Preserve that abbreviation in a supplied witness note, not the expanded January.

Evidence: 05-146-date, 05-147-date.

05-146-U008 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-146-P04 | [[illegible: remainder in shadow and cropped]] → Remainder of Mary Roper's acknowledgment is visible on 05-147-P02

The printed and inserted handwritten names align exactly. The clearer scan exposes the remainder beginning been examined by me privily and apart from her husband and its dated signature. The shadow/crop marker remains on scan 146, with a reference to the complete acknowledgment.

Evidence: 05-146-bottom, 05-147-roper.

05-147-U002 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-147-P04 | [[obscured: overlying sheet]] → Covered opening appears on 05-149-P02

The exposed continuation of the Said E L Winniford matches the uncovered acknowledgment in scan 149. The name of the notary remains partly unresolved there; do not import the earlier Raepth Sudris guess as certain text.

Evidence: 05-147-bottom, 05-149-opening, 05-149-ending.

05-147-U004 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-147-P04 | [[lost: cropped bottom]] → Continuation and closing visible on 05-149-P02-P03

The text ending consideration therein Expressed is followed in the uncovered scan by and that She did not wish to retract it and the dated closing. Retain the crop marker and cite the fuller witness.

Evidence: 05-147-bottom, 05-149-ending.

05-148-U001 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-148-P03 | [[obscured: overlying sheet]] → Covered opening appears on 05-149-P02

The lower exposed words and their line breaks match the same underlying sheet shown fully in 05-149. Keep the obstruction marker and link that witness; this duplicates the finding for 05-147-U002.

Evidence: 05-148-bottom, 05-149-opening, 05-149-ending.

05-148-U003 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-148-P03 | [[illegible: shadow]] → and Seal this Fourth, verified on 05-149-P03

The obscured closing aligns with the uncovered scan. Brightening scan 148 does not independently recover every letter; scan 149 visibly supplies and Seal this Fourth.

Evidence: 05-148-bottom, 05-149-ending.

05-148-U004 | Clearer duplicate witness

05-148-P03 | [[lost: cropped bottom]] → Closing signature and commission note continue on 05-149-P03

The complete underlying sheet carries the date, notary's signature, office and commission-expiry note. Preserve uncertainties in those elements, including the given name and expiry reading, rather than filling the cropped area with confident guesses.

Evidence: 05-148-bottom, 05-149-ending.

05-149-U001 | Partial reading

05-149-P02 | [[Raept Sudris?]] → [given name unread] Guthrie

Both the body and signature show G-u-t-h-r-i-e. The given name remains difficult; neither Raept nor Reese is established. Recover only the surname and retain an explicit uncertainty for the given name.

Evidence: 05-149-opening, 05-149-ending.

05-149-U003 | Partial reading

05-149-P03 | [[Raept Sudris?]] → [given name unread] Guthrie

The repeated surname in the signature confirms Guthrie. This is a second occurrence of the same notary's name, not independent biographical identification. Leave the given name unread.

Evidence: 05-149-ending, 05-149-opening.

06-008-U003 | Image-supported reading

06-008-P02 | [[91?]] → 91; certificate on 06-011 says 92

The docket's final digit is a single ascending stroke, matching 1, without the curved head and lower return of 2. The separately written certificate visibly says 92. Preserve 91 here and report the disagreement; do not harmonize the two documents.

Evidence: 06-008-docket, 06-011-record.

06-008-U004 | Unresolved

06-008-P02 | [[2.75?]] → 2.75 / 2.50 unresolved

The amount is very faded. The last stroke resembles 5, but the preceding cents digit is not reliable enough to settle the competing proposals. The paid amount cannot be inferred from the deed-book reference.

Evidence: 06-008-docket.

06-063-U001 | Image-supported reading

06-063-P01 | [[Stinnet?]] → Claunch

The enlarged word shows Cl, au and the nch ending. The separate report in 04-017 uses the same surname for a similar reported event. This corroborates the transcription; the accusation remains the letter writer's account.

Evidence: 06-063-opening, 04-017-claunch.

06-063-U002 | Image-supported reading

06-063-P01 | [[S?]] → C

The abbreviation after Mrs is an open, rounded capital C, matching the initial of Claunch in the previous clause. Retain C rather than expanding the surname into the literal text.

Evidence: 06-063-opening.

06-063-U003 | Unresolved

06-063-P01 | [[Simons?]] → Simons / Simmons / Jennings unresolved

The initial resembles S more than J, but the small interior strokes are broken. Simons or Simmons may fit; the scan does not justify resolving the name. Neither family-version agreement nor the murder narrative proves the brother's identity.

Evidence: 06-063-opening.

06-063-U004 | Unresolved

06-063-P01 | [[illegible]] → Span before creek remains unread

The line is badly faded and the earlier surrounding transcription may also be inaccurate. A possible reference to Waxahachie is only a lead. The whole line needs a fresh transcription; no word is inserted into the current gap.

Evidence: 06-063-opening.

06-116-U001 | Unresolved

06-116-P02 | [[Lis's?]] → Lis's / alternative place or activity unresolved

Native crop and darkening do not establish the destination or activity. The two editions disagree in surrounding names and syntax, so the old word boundaries themselves are not a reliable template for filling this slot.

Evidence: 06-116-opening.

06-116-U002 | Unresolved

06-116-P02 | [[illegible]] → Unclear span before Bro Goodman retained

Some strokes survive but do not support a complete reading. The opening needs line-by-line retranscription from a better witness; avoid turning a grammatical expectation into text.

Evidence: 06-116-opening.

06-116-U003 | Unresolved

06-116-P02 | [[illegible]] → Unclear span after preached retained

The faded line appears different from the earlier transcript in several places. Neither darkening nor OCR establishes the words between the current anchors.

Evidence: 06-116-opening.

06-116-U004 | Unresolved

06-116-P02 | [[illegible]] → Unclear span before discourse retained

The earlier confident anchor literary is itself questionable on this image. Keep this gap and flag the entire clause for review instead of accepting a fluent reconstruction around possibly wrong anchors.

Evidence: 06-116-opening.

06-116-U005 | Unresolved

06-116-P02 | [[illegible]] → Unclear span after He retained

Several letter fragments are visible, but they do not establish a continuous phrase. OCR returns unstable strings. No complete reading is defensible from the supplied copy in this pilot.

Evidence: 06-116-opening.